



**From the album:** [clockwise from facing page] Mohun Bagan striker Jose Barreto (right) and Vasco SC defender Sebi Dias vie for the ball during a National Football League match; action from the inaugural Indian Super League (ISL) fixture between Atletico de Kolkata and Mumbai City FC; Bhaichung Bhutia in action for Mohun Bagan during an I-League encounter. PICS: THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

**8. Pitch queens:** The Indian Women's League (IWL) was launched with six teams to provide a national league for women's football. Earlier, the top competition was the Senior Women's National Championship, the women's equivalent of the Santosh Trophy. IWL winners qualify for the AFC Women's Champions League.

**10. Change in setup:** After discussions between the AIFF and the AFC on the future roadmap of Indian football, the ISL was granted the status of the premier league competition in the country. This change allowed the ISL champion to represent India in the AFC Champions League playoffs, while the I-League winner earned a spot in the AFC Cup playoffs.

**12. International woes:** India made its third AFC Asian Cup appearance since 1996 but once again failed to progress beyond the group stage, as in 2011 and 2019. In the Asian Games, the team's best result since its Golden Era golds in 1951 and 1962 remained a Round of 16 finish — achieved in 2010 and 2022.

2016

2017

**9. Home stage:** India made its debut in the men's edition of the FIFA U-17 World Cup as the host but finished bottom of the group, failing to reach the knockouts.

2019

2022

2023

**11. A new addition:** Following further AFC recommendations, the AIFF announced that from the 2022-23 season, the I-League champion would gain automatic promotion to the ISL without having to pay a participation fee. However, the promoted team would need to meet the national club licensing criteria set by the AIFF. After winning the 2022-23 I-League title, Punjab FC became the first team to gain automatic promotion to the ISL. Meanwhile, India hosted the 2022 edition of the FIFA U-17 Women's World Cup but once again failed to progress beyond the group stage. The tournament was originally scheduled for 2020 but was postponed due to the COVID-19 pandemic.

